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Overfield . . .

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Armbrister's bunt, then threw wildly past second base. The Sox protested vehemently, arguing that Armbrister interfered with Fisk, but to no avail. Joe Morgan's single won the game in extra innings and his blooper won the seventh game.

OVERFIELD'S main interest in baseball, though, was his hometown team, the Bisons.

He followed them from the first time he attended a Bison game in 1925 until their demise in War Memorial Stadium 1970, where their last game was played.

"I got to attend my first game when my brother and I clipped free-game coupons out of The Buffalo Evening News and walked to old Bison Stadium," said Overfield. The stadium was only two years old when I saw my first game," he continued.

"The diamond at Michigan and Ferry had been the home of Buffalo baseball since 1889, when old Olympic Park was carted board by board from Richmond and Summer and a new park was built," he said.

"Connie Mack played there in 1890, and Jimmy Collins, the greatest of all Buffalo-born players, began his career here in 1893. Bill (Derby Day) Clymer, who later was to manage the Bisons, played on the 1897 Bison outfield with two other redheads, and Zane Grey, the noted author, wrote a famous story which he called 'The Red-Headed Outfield.' One was Zane's brother, Reddy," continued Overfield.

Overfield then looked at a picture of the 1878 Bisons, the first team to play in a regular league — the International Association. They were the first Buffalo pro team and they won the league title the first year they played.

OVERFIELD maintains the strongest Bison team was the 1927 champions, managed by Clymer, and led by first baseman Del Bissonette, who batted .365 that year, and shortstop Andy Cohen. The Herd won the pennant in a walkaway, but lost the Little World Series to the Toledo Mud Hens, managed by Casey Stengel.

Overfield recalls the 1933 Bisons as the most-exciting because they finished below .500 and barely made the playoffs by winning 14 of their last 17 games. Managed by Ray Schalk, the '33 Bisons were led by Ollie Carnegie, who later set International League and all-time Bison home-run records, they drew perhaps the largest crowd (20,000) ever to see a Bison game but lost to Columbus in the Little World Series.

Then the 1936 Bisons, led by the great outfield of Carnegie, Beauty McGowan in center and Eddie Boland in right, with powerful Johnny Dickshot supplanting Carnegie. The infield was comprised of Elbie Fletcher at first, Marv Olson at second, Greg Mulleavy at shortstop and Butch Meyers at third.

The pitching staff included Ken Ash, Rip Sewell, Bill Harris, Bob Kline, and Carl Fischer, the Medina native. Bucky Crouse was the catcher, and he was a great one. Again, the Bisons won the playoffs, but lost the Little World Series to Milwaukee.

WATCHING Bison teams over the years, Overfield saw the best players and the greatest feats in old Offermann Stadium.

He remembers the first Buffalo night game (July 3, 1930); the night Dave Danforth struck out 20 Rochester Red Wings (also 1930); watching the Bisons lose the Little World Series in 1933 to Columbus, when Bill Lee and Paul Dean pitched for the Red

Birds. Both were stars later with the Cubs and Cards, respectively.

He was at the stadium when Bob Veale, who later starred with Pittsburgh, struck out 22 Bisons for Columbus on May 10, 1962.

He'll always remember the two home runs the great Luke Easter hit over the scoreboard, something that no one ever dreamed would happen.

"John Stiglmeier's signing of Easter was one of the smartest moves ever made by the team. It made community ownership go for several years, though it was a delaying game.. Harry Bisgeier also deserves much credit for the Bisons' success those years," he said.

Overfield was there the night the late Jackie Robinson, who broke baseball's color line in the majors, played his first game in Offermann for the Montreal Royals.

ONE OF OVERFIELD'S proudest moments was selecting the all-time Bison team with Cy Kritzer, retired baseball writer of The News, and Joe Alli in 1964, the year of the gala Bison Old Timer's reunion in the Buffalo Athletic Club.

Elaborate plans at the stadium were wiped out by week-long rains, but the parties went far into the night at the BAC.

Overfield has a candidate for "The most Unforgettable Person I've Met" contest.

He's Lee Allen, who for years was official baseball historian at Cooperstown before his death about 10 years ago. "He was a brilliant writer and his main interest was in old-time players. He wrote many articles for magazines, had a regular column in the Sporting News, and wrote several books.

YOU MIGHT wonder how Overfield got started with this

hobby of being baseball historian. "I was looking through old records in County Hall and I came across the financial statement of the 1878 Bisons, and it aroused my curiosity," he continued.

That ignited one of the most determined research minds in the sport. After all, Overfield's business is research. He's been in the real estate title business since 1937, and is vice president of the Buffalo office of Monroe Abstract & Title.

WHILE HE played Midget League American Legion baseball, he never went further as a participant, but his interest never lagged.

He's totally against the use of the designated hitter (batting for the pitcher) and the artificial playing fields.

He also belives the Reserve Clause was the glue that kept baseball alive many years, though he realizes it was illegal.

"TODAY'S SALARIES for most major-leaguers are preposterous," he said. "The spectators can't keep on absorbing the players' salary increases in their ticket costs," he continued.

"The free agent situation eventually may reach a point where it's not economically sound to run a baseball team," he continued.

Despite the current shaky status of baseball's financial structure, he's solidly behind the sport.

"The beauty of baseball is that it's a game of individual skill and yet it's a team game. It takes skill to hit a curveball or a fastball at 90 miles an hour. The pickoff plays must be well-executed to be successful. It takes timing and teamwork.

"To me, its the perfect game," he concluded.